

then director-general of police. It was during the last election campaign that Mayawati promised to investigate the mass recruitment drive. After coming to power, she lost no time in ordering the inquiry. Says Mulayam, "The Mayawati Government is on a witch-hunt. The action smacks of political vendetta."

This is perhaps the first time that such a scandal has been detected in the recruitment of policemen in India and action taken against the accused. The inquiry has thrown up some startling facts. It has found that a substantial number of candidates were selected despite a criminal record, on the basis of fake SC/ST/OBC and birth certificates. While the chairmen and the members of the selection boards obliged unqualified candidates for obvious reasons, upper caste candidates were deliberately denied the opportunity. The selection board in Etah, headed by senior police officer Akhilesh Mehrotra, conducted one thousand interviews in less than 12 hours, which means each interview—which included verification of photograph, documents and certificates—took less than 45 seconds. According to the report, 20-30 candidates might have been interviewed in a group, in gross violation of norms.

From the very beginning, a substantial number of upper caste applicants were summarily rejected to make way for OBCs, particularly Yadavs, says a member of the inquiry panel. Their scores in the physical fitness and written tests were tampered with, he adds. Mehrotra authorised the interviews of 35 candidates who had failed in the written examinations.

Favouritism in the police is not a new phenomenon, says a senior police officer, adding that the practice had been prevalent even during the British period. The British favoured recruiting those who they thought would be loyal to them. Post-Independence, constables were selected on the basis of their physical characteristic. The Mulayam

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DEFENSIVE: Mulayam Singh terms the suspensions "political vendetta"

government adopted the loyalty criterion hoping to build a force that could be used against political rivals.

Mayawati, on her part, may have done away with thousands of black sheep in Uttar Pradesh's police force, but with the Government sparing Muslim and Dalit officers, the matter has assumed political overtones. Other than the recommendation of a formal departmental enquiry, no serious action has been taken against them. The officers have not been suspended and no criminal cases have been registered against them. Just two days before the suspension of the 12 IPS officers was announced, a group of Muslim leaders led by Zafaryab Jilani of the All-India Muslim Personal Law Board, Naib Imam of the Aishbagh Idgah, Maulana Khalid Rashid Firangi and

Shia cleric Maulana Yasoob Abbas had issued a statement urging the Government to spare the Muslims, on the grounds that it would be difficult for them to find employment.

Also noteworthy is the fact that though many recruited candidates have been found to be colour blind, the chief medical officer who issued fitness certificates to them has not been brought to book. Nor has any action been taken against those who issued character certificates to those with criminal records. "This Government's days are numbered. It has been taking undemocratic decisions," says Mulayam.

While weeding out undeserving officers might spare the Uttar Pradesh Police further infamy, there is a danger that the dismissed might turn against the state. "Keeping tabs on the suspended police personnel, now well-trained in handling weapons and explosives, will remain a headache for the state. In the past, police personnel of lower ranks in Punjab and Jammu and Kashmir had even joined the underworld," says a senior officer. Hopefully, the Government will be able to prevent such officers from subverting the system. ■

TAMPER PROOF

■ A large number of general category candidates were rejected in the preliminary stage of recruitment and not allowed to sit for the examinations.

■ Long jump scores were tampered with to favour a few; marks in tests such as ball throw and sit-ups were changed without a signature.

■ In the name of rechecking, the chairmen of selection boards increased the marks of candidates who failed in the written exams. They examined a large number of papers.

■ Some candidates who did not pass the written test were also called for interviews.

■ The interviews were held two days before the scheduled date.

■ Members of the board did not sign the sheet containing marks given during interviews.